

THE DURAND LINE

“A frontier shaped by history, geography, and politics.”

A line on a map can become much more than a line. It can become a frontier. A political boundary. A security zone. A route of migration. A memory of partition. A source of disagreement. And for communities living near it, an everyday reality. The Durand Line emerged from a nineteenth-century agreement between the British Indian government and the Afghan Amir. Its history did not end with the agreement. The line was subsequently surveyed, marked and administered through changing political circumstances. After 1947, the question entered a new chapter as Afghanistan and the new state of Pakistan developed their own positions toward the frontier. For Orakzai and other Pashtun communities, the history of this frontier cannot be understood only through governments. It must also be understood through geography, kinship, movement, trade, memory and the changing meaning of borders.

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"A conceptual visualization of the Durand Line: a cartographic boundary intersecting a shared mountain landscape."

WHAT IS THE DURAND LINE?

The Durand Line refers to the frontier associated with the 1893 agreement between the Government of British India and Amir Abdur Rahman Khan of Afghanistan. The agreement was not a simple border decree but a complex settlement concerning the respective spheres of influence and the frontier relationship between the two governments.

BRITISH INDIA

AFGHAN AMIR

1893 FRONTIER AGREEMENT

SPHERES OF INFLUENCE

“The fundamental architecture of the 1893 Agreement.”

THE PEOPLE BEHIND THE AGREEMENT

SIR MORTIMER DURAND

Position: Foreign Secretary to the Government of India.

Role in 1893: Chief British negotiator who traveled to Kabul to secure the frontier agreement.

Context: Represented British imperial interests during the 'Great Game' rivalry with Russia.

AMIR ABDUR RAHMAN KHAN

Position: Amir of Afghanistan (r. 1880–1901).

Role in 1893: Negotiated to stabilize his borders and secure a British subsidy and munitions.

Context: Known as the 'Iron Amir', he sought to consolidate the Afghan state.

THE 1893 AGREEMENT

Signed on November 12, 1893, in Kabul, the agreement consisted of seven articles. It was a diplomatic instrument intended to settle "questions regarding the frontier of Afghanistan on the side of India." The document explicitly stated that the frontier would follow a line shown in an attached map, and both governments undertook not to interfere in the territories beyond that line.

BEFORE

NEGOTIATION

AGREEMENT

ADMINISTRATION

KEY PRINCIPLES OF 1893

Defined Spheres of Influence | Non-Interference Commitment
Increased Subsidy | Future Joint Demarcation

“The logical progression from negotiation to administration.”

THE DURAND COMMISSION & DEMARCATION

The agreement provided for joint British and Afghan commissioners to lay down the frontier in detail and demarcate it on the ground. Between 1894 and 1896, several commissions worked in different sections of the frontier, surveying the terrain and placing approximately 258 boundary markers. However, not every section was demarcated in the same way or at the same time, and some areas remained only roughly defined by geography.

AGREEMENT

SURVEY

DEMARCATIION

ADMINISTRATION

AGREEMENT ≠ PHYSICAL DEMARCATION

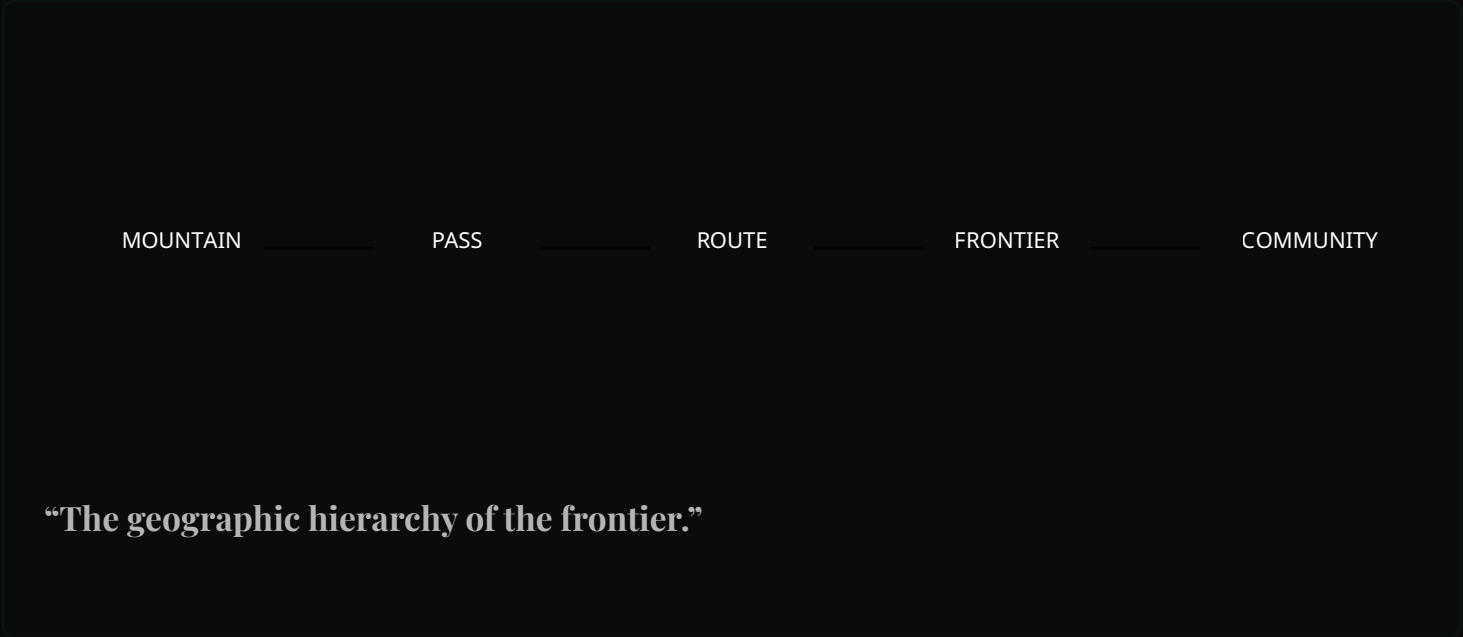
The 1893 text defined the concept; the Commission defined the ground.

“Distinguishing between the diplomatic agreement and the physical demarcation.”

A LINE THROUGH A MOUNTAIN LANDSCAPE

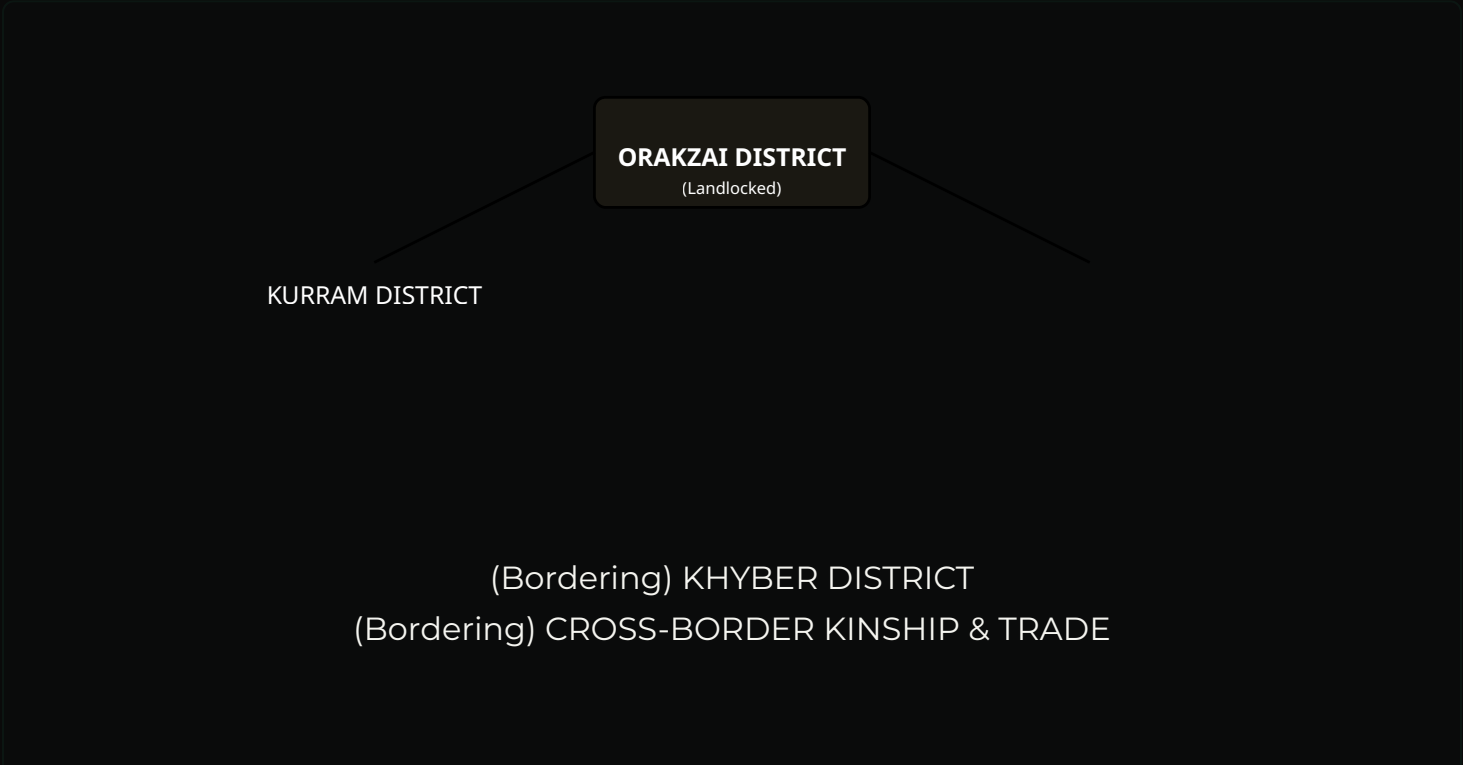
The frontier was not drawn in a vacuum; it followed the physical geography of the region. Mountain ridges, valleys, passes, and rivers shaped the practical course of the boundary. In many places, the line followed the watershed of the Hindu Kush and other ranges, turning

natural barriers into political limits. For communities living in these valleys, the line often cut across traditional routes and seasonal migration paths.



ORAKZAI AND THE FRONTIER

Geographically, Orakzai is the only tribal district that does not share a direct border with Afghanistan. It is landlocked, surrounded by the neighboring districts of Kurram and Khyber, which do share the international boundary. However, the Orakzai tribe—including sections like the Mamozai—has historically maintained deep cross-border ties. These relationships were forged through migration, trade routes, and kinship networks that extended through the passes of Kurram and Khyber into Afghan territory.



“Visualizing Orakzai's indirect but deep connection to the frontier.”

PASHTUN COMMUNITIES AND THE BORDER

For Pashtun communities, the Durand Line bisected a shared cultural and social space. Kinship, language, and trade continued across the line, often ignoring the formal administrative boundaries of the state. While governments saw a border, communities saw a network of relationships. This duality has created a "living borderland" where identity and citizenship do not always align perfectly.⁵

FAMILY

KINSHIP

TRADE

BORDER

IDENTITY

“The fluid exchange between social pillars and the political border.”

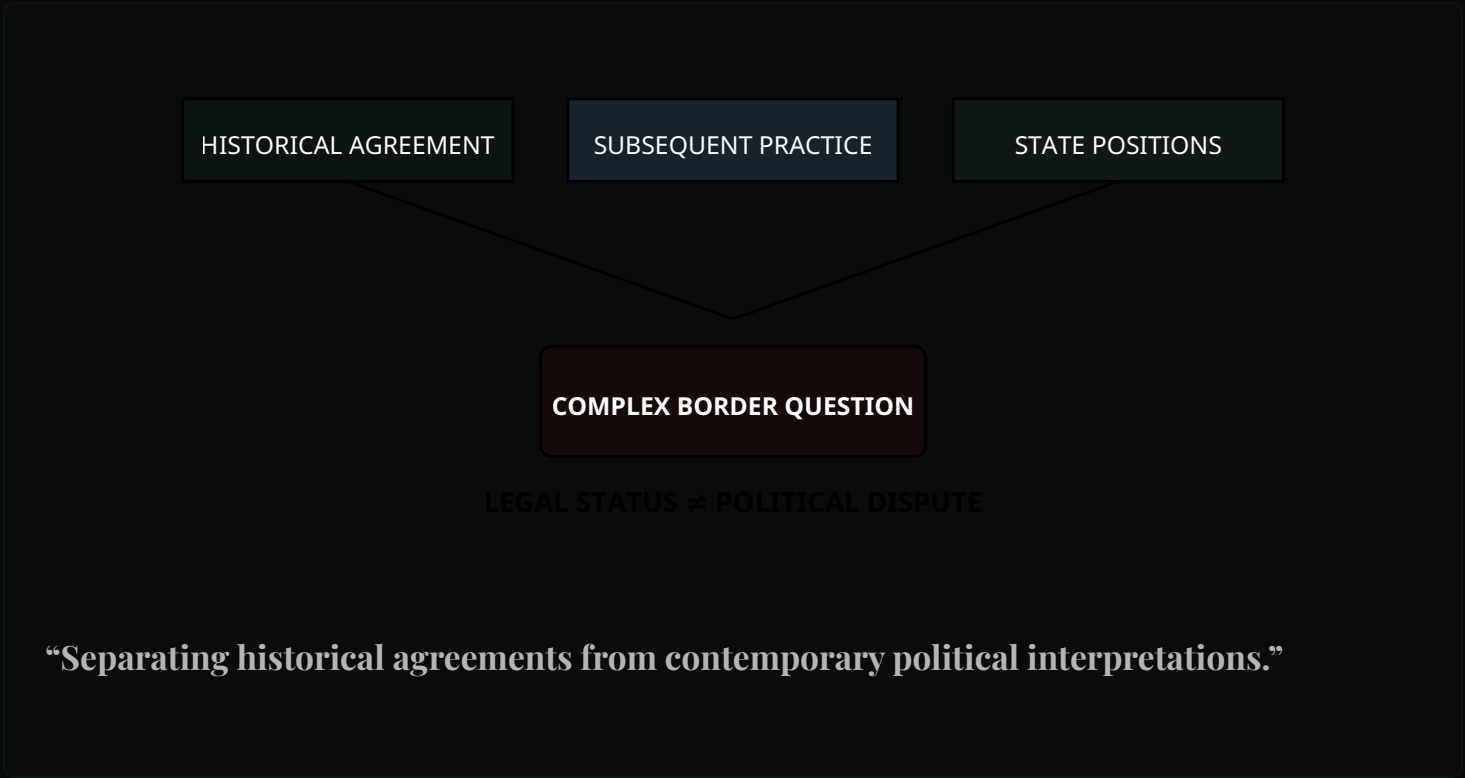
1919 AND THE 1921 TREATIES

Following the Third Anglo-Afghan War in 1919, the Treaty of Rawalpindi explicitly reaffirmed the frontier accepted by the late Amir. This was further solidified in the 1921 Anglo-Afghan Treaty of Friendship, where both parties mutually accepted the Indo-Afghan frontier. These treaties are critical legal milestones that have historically defined the diplomatic recognition of the boundary between the two states.^{2 3}

1947 AND THE CONTEMPORARY DISPUTE

With the independence of Pakistan in 1947, the new state inherited the international boundary as the successor to British India. However, the Afghan government at the time raised questions concerning the status of the frontier, advocating for a third option of independence for Pashtun territories. This has led to a long-standing diplomatic dispute, with Pakistan

asserting its territorial integrity and Afghanistan historically maintaining a different political position.



MYTH: “The entire border was created in a single moment in 1893.”

EVIDENCE: The 1893 agreement was followed by years of survey, demarcation, and subsequent treaties in 1905, 1919, and 1921.

BORDER FENCING AND THE MODERN REALITY

Since 2017, Pakistan has undertaken a massive project to fence the Durand Line to enhance border security and manage cross-border movement. This physical barrier has significantly changed the lived experience for tribal communities, transforming a historically porous frontier into a managed international border. While aimed at state security, the fence has disrupted traditional trade and kinship networks, marking a new chapter in the history of the frontier.⁷

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

A border can be politically defined in a document. But people experience borders differently. They experience them through roads, through checkpoints, through passports and permits,

and through family members who live on different sides. The Durand Line therefore cannot be understood only as a historical agreement. It is also a story about geography, political power, migration, identity and memory. For Orakzai history, the important question is not only where the line was drawn. It is also how people living in and around the frontier experienced the changes that followed. History becomes more honest when we separate what the documents prove from what communities remember. Both matter. But they are not the same thing.

“A BORDER CAN DIVIDE TERRITORY. HISTORY REMEMBERS THE PEOPLE WHO LIVED THROUGH IT.”

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS
